

Chicago Tribune



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WEDNESDAY, DECEMBER 31, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

OPERATION MIDWAY BLITZ

What did CPD ‘assistance’ entail?

Audio of Border Patrol, 911 dispatchers sheds more light on local police response

By **Caroline Kubzansky**
Chicago Tribune

On the second day of Border Patrol Cmdr. Gregory Bovino’s brief, chaotic return to Chicago earlier this month, a U.S. Customs and Border Protection supervisor dialed 911 as a convoy of federal vehicles sped north on DuSable Lake Shore Drive.

“This is Supervisory Border

Patrol Agent (redacted),” the agent said. “How are you doing today?”

The 12-minute conversation that followed between the 911 dispatcher, her supervisor and the Border Patrol supervisor shows that while Chicago police and emergency personnel did not assist Bovino’s caravan in its arrests or other immigration enforcement, local authorities coordinated with federal agents to meet their

convoy as it traveled north toward Evanston and divert a pair of cars which the Border Patrol supervisor claimed were “trying to run us off the road.”

Bovino, speaking with a Tribune photographer in the parking lot of an Evanston Home Depot later that day, said he and his men had “for the first time, (received) some assistance” from local law enforcement during their brief return to the area.

Bovino didn’t elaborate on what that “assistance” was at the time, and the Chicago Police Depart-

ment said in a statement that its personnel “only responded to the call they received regarding potential criminal action.”

The 911 call and other newly released records show that Chicago police activated one of the department’s helicopters, stopped a man who had been following the federal convoy and gave him a “verbal warning” about driving while using a cellphone while responding to the feds’ “assist the police” request.

And they highlight once again the fine line that local law enforcement in Illinois has had to strad-

dle throughout Operation Midway Blitz, the Trump administration’s campaign to arrest and deport people living in and around Chicago without legal immigration status.

While they are prohibited from aiding federal authorities with immigration enforcement, city police and other state and local agencies are still obligated to respond to general public safety threats and maintain order.

Reached for a comment Monday

Turn to Police, Page 4



Workers continue their construction of Northwestern University’s Ryan Field in Evanston on Nov. 21. The stadium’s exterior is complete and it’s expected to be finished ahead of the planned 2026 opening in September. **DOMINIC DI PALERMO/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Ryan Field touted as ‘the best place to watch a football game’

Northwestern’s new \$862M stadium to have 35,000 seats, canopy roof, better sight lines

By **Robert Channick**
Chicago Tribune

As Northwestern, fresh off a bowl win, wraps up its second season of playing football at a small lakefront field shared with the lacrosse and soccer teams, workers are busy building out a new \$862 million football stadium in Evanston.

Beginning next season, the Wildcats, once the doormat of the Big Ten, may finally have home field advantage over their conference rivals.

After nearly a century at the concrete stadium formerly known as Dyche, and two seasons

at the temporary lakefront facility, Northwestern will christen what it believes to be the most fan-friendly major college football venue in the U.S. when the new Ryan Field opens in the fall.

“It’ll be the best place to watch a football game in America,” said Pat Ryan Jr., whose family drove the project and funded the majority of the money needed to build their namesake stadium.

Northwestern announced plans for the privately funded Ryan Field rebuild in 2022. The modern open-air stadium includes a canopy roof, better sight lines, chair backs instead of benches and 35,000 seats —

12,000 fewer than the old Ryan Field, which was demolished in 2024 after the Evanston City Council narrowly approved the project.

Unlike older stadiums, including its predecessor, newer construction technology allows seating levels that are steeper and closer to the field — a more intimate experience similar to a modern basketball arena.

The primary benefactor of the new stadium is insurance billionaire Patrick Ryan, founder and retired CEO of Aon Corp. and a Northwestern alumnus. The Ryan family donated \$480 million in 2021 — the largest

gift in Northwestern history — in large part to help build the stadium, and has since committed additional funding as the cost of the project has risen.

His son, Pat Ryan Jr., 58, a technology entrepreneur who holds a law and MBA degree from Northwestern, led the stadium redevelopment, navigating a contentious approval process that included calls to halt the ambitious project in the wake of a hazing scandal and July 2023 firing of the football team’s coach, Pat Fitzgerald.

In August, Northwestern reached a settlement agreement

Turn to Stadium, Page 2

9TH CONGRESSIONAL DISTRICT

Leon to drop out of Dem primary

Says AIPAC pressured him to exit race to unify support for Fine

By **Olivia Olander**
Chicago Tribune

A candidate in the crowded Democratic primary to replace retiring U.S. Rep. Jan Schakowsky said Tuesday he plans to drop out of the race following a pressure campaign from AIPAC, an influential but controversial pro-Israel lobbying organization.

The development appears to be a boon to state Sen. Laura Fine, another Democratic candidate who supports Israel and seems to have received the interest group’s tacit backing.

Bruce Leon, an Orthodox Jew and a staunch supporter of Israel, said the American Israel Public Affairs Committee pressured him for months to drop out of the 9th Congressional District race to consolidate support for Fine, who has more widespread backing and has been endorsed by dozens of Democratic leaders in the district. AIPAC’s push was previously reported by the outlet Evanston Now.

The final straw for Leon came this week, after AIPAC successfully pressured leaders within his own Orthodox Jewish community to also push him to the sidelines, Leon told the Tribune.

“AIPAC has been breathing down the rabbis’ necks,” Leon, who said he previously donated thousands of dollars annually to the organization, said this week.

The North Side and north suburban 9th District seat has long been held in Congress by Jewish representatives. Before Schakowsky, who is Jewish, was elected in 1998, the district was represented by the late Democratic U.S. Rep. Sidney Yates, who was also Jewish,

Turn to Race, Page 4

INSIDE



AUDREY RICHARDSON/TRIBUNE

The most memorable food, drinks of 2025

From pizza to pasta salad to pie, the writers and editors of the Tribune’s food section reflect on year’s best bites and drinks. **Food & Health**

TRUMP ALTERS GOVERNMENT:

The impact of a shrunken federal workforce and reduced services is still unclear. **Nation & World**

Christmas comes late for family who lost home in fire

Outpouring of support from loved ones, neighbors, strangers

By **Tess Kenny**
Chicago Tribune

Leandrea and John Hernández started gathering gifts in October. After years of small Christmases on tight budgets, the Zion couple wanted to ensure that everyone — from their four kids to extended family — would be tearing open wrapping paper on Christmas.

That moment never came.

On Christmas Eve, a fire destroyed the Hernández family’s north suburban home of the past six years. They lost everything, gifts and all, leaving the family

of eight to figure out what’s next while they waded through their grief.

It’s been unimaginable and overwhelming, they say.

But they’ve been getting by with the community’s help thanks to an outpouring of support for the family, with loved ones and neighbors and even strangers donating what they can to alleviate the loss.

“We were broken,” said Leandrea Hernández, 36. “We still are broken. ... But then I get online at 2, 3, 4 o’clock in the morning when I can’t sleep, and people are still donating, sharing our GoFundMe, sending meals. Telling me, ‘What else can we do?’

Turn to Family, Page 5



Leandrea Hernández, center, comforts her mother, Katrina Smith, left, as they talk about the Christmas Eve fire that destroyed their home in Zion on Dec. 27. Hernández’s son Aiden Hernández, 13, listens. **MICHAEL SCHMIDT/FOR THE CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

